

a) I was going to have a wedding and
 b) I was just going to have a wedding.
 It wasn't going to be the social event of the year, but it didn't have to be. Consequently, I laughed a lot more and did things the way I wanted them done, not the way I hoped others would like. My way was cheaper and more relaxed.

CLOTHES

12. Research, research, research!

I got my dress for several hundred dollars less than retail because I spent several hours (spread out) researching it and the places I could buy it. It was perfect, and I didn't have to spend a fortune.

13. Rent them

Look on the web for sites that rent children's formal and dress clothing at a reasonable price and for a reasonable amount of time. There's not much of a point in spending \$70 on a child's tux you can keep for three days, when you can spend less money and have it for three weeks.

14. Make your own

If you are a seamstress, or know someone who is, make your own

clothes, particularly for the flower girls. There are a million cheap and easy patterns out there, and cute material goes on sale quite often. My mom made my flower girl dresses, and they were darling.

15. Shop fabric and craft store sales

At the end of a season, these stores sell all the fabric that's obviously from the previous season at truly amazing prices. My flower girl dresses are a linen-look fabric from this summer that I purchased at half-price in September. Because I live in LA, it was still appropriate for the wedding.

16. HouseOfBrides.com

I purchased my wedding dress from them and I couldn't rave more about the service they offer. It's a "no frills" sort of thing, and you have to give them enough time and trust that it will come. If they carry your dress and you're ordering far enough in advance, they can save you a bundle.

17. Don't buy boutique, but do try it on there

Boutique markups are ridiculous (or funny, if you're me and you al-

